NASM VIRTUAL COACHING SPECIALIST (VCS)

Chapter 6: Implementing Coaching Sessions

National Academy of Sports Medicine — Evidence-Based Telehealth Curriculum

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching Sessions
Lesson 1Session Preparation

Implementing virtual training sessions requires organization and development of a proper training environment, exercise equipment, instructional components, and compliance monitoring. Recommendations and guidance for appropriate spacing, flooring, lighting, camera angles, equipment, and coaching cues will all be provided in this chapter.

Learning Objectives

After completing this chapter, the NASM Virtual Coach will have the ability to do the following:

- **Summarize** different methods for configuring a virtual training environment.
- **Identify** appropriate training equipment for clients.
- **Summarize** best practices for presenting in the virtual training space.
- **Compare** ways to instruct individual, small, and large group fitness classes virtually.
- **Explain** ways to implement safety protocols in a virtual training session.
- **Describe** ways to provide nutritional guidance virtually.

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Introduction

New technologies are constantly changing the way people live across generations. Advancements, such as smartphones and personal computers, are revolutionizing how people interact with both their physical and virtual worlds and the health and fitness industry is no exception (Banos & Nugent, 2018). The job outlook for fitness professionals is expected to increase by 15% in the next decade (**Figure: Employment Projections**) and, with the surge in demand for online delivery of fitness programs, much of this could be composed of fitness professionals operating virtually (U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, 2020).



U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, 2020

FigureEmployment Projections

Fitness professionals engaging in virtual training have a variety of methods from which they can conduct their business. For example, they may choose to provide live or prerecorded training sessions, one-on-one training, or virtual group fitness classes. The attributes required to run a virtual training business are not unlike those required for in-person training. Professionalism, coaching competency, fitness knowledge, and communication skills play vital roles on both ends of the fitness coaching spectrum.

However, there are several components that require additional consideration in virtual coaching sessions when compared with traditional in-person fitness training. Fitness professionals implementing virtual coaching sessions will need to ensure they have all of the necessary equipment and recording and scheduling tools to effectively conduct their business and training sessions online.

In the online training space, clients only have access to the fitness professional through video conferencing, voice calls, or messaging tools. Through these mediums, the client is peering into the fitness professional's "virtual world;" therefore, the fitness professional must understand how to effectively create, manage, and adjust each component of their virtual world to provide the best training experience for their clients.



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Session Preparation

Operating in the virtual fitness space allows a fitness professional to interact with more clients than they would have been able to while doing in-person training. The time gaps between appointments are typically much smaller than in a typical face-to-face environment, and the fitness professional or nutrition coach can remain in the same location from session to session. Clients also benefit from the convenience of virtual training as they can access their coach from the comfort of their own homes and even on the go. Due to this increased accessibility, it is vital that the fitness professional be well-prepared and organized in their virtual training business. The quality of the fitness professional's preparation may dictate the success of the session. Selecting appropriate video conferencing tools, scheduling and confirming appointments, and preparing workouts are the foundational requirements of a virtual training business.

Video Recording



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Coaching clients virtually requires some form of video recording and conferencing software. Both video calls and pre-recorded workouts or instructions require access to a quality camera, a computer or smartphone, high-speed Internet connections, and a method to efficiently share the videos with clients. Virtual storage space, upload bandwidth, download capacity, and ease of access will need to be considered by both the client and fitness professional. Using applications that provide large storage space (e.g., Vimeo, Dropbox, or YouTube) is recommended for professionals sharing prerecorded workouts with their clients. For live, 1-to-1 or group virtual coaching sessions, video conferencing applications are recommended (e.g., Zoom, Skype, WebEx, Google Meets, etc.). Advancements in video conferencing technologies have made them considerably useful, essentially indispensable, tools for fitness professionals operating virtually. Appointments can be scheduled, confirmed, and conducted all from a single application.

Helpful Hint

Beginner Tips for Recording Great Videos on a Smartphone

❏ Record in landscape mode (horizontally).

❏ Check phone settings.

- Video resolution refers to the size of the video file. The most commonly used video resolutions are 1080 HD and 4K, with the latter being the larger of the two. The higher the video resolution, the clearer the video will be. However, higher resolution also means a much larger file size. Video resolution should be considered in conjunction with file storage options.
- Frame rate is measured in frames per second (fps). The phone should be set at either 30 fps or 60 fps. The higher the fps, the smoother the video will look.

❏ Clean the camera lens with a microfiber cloth before each recording.

❏ Use both hands to hold the phone or invest in a tripod mount.

❏ Avoid using the camera flash. Instead, use other available light sources to light the subject.

❏ Avoid backlit settings.

❏ Experiment with slow-motion and time-lapse effects for variety.

❏ Take advantage of basic editing features on a mobile device, such as trimming, transitioning, and other effects.

Scheduling Appointments

As with in-person training, virtual training requires scheduling and organization. The fitness professional should determine availability, session length/duration, and hours of operation and clearly communicate these to clients. To maintain organization and avoid overbooking appointments, the fitness professional will need to choose a scheduling system suitable for their business format.

Scheduling via virtual technologies (e.g., Calendly, Vocus.io, ScheduleOnce, Zoom, etc.) are efficient ways for both the fitness professional and client to communicate and confirm appointments. These technologies have made scheduling intuitive, accounting for time-zone differences, providing reminders and notifications of upcoming appointments, as well as allowing for multiple app integrations and customizations. Utilizing these tools certainly enhances the organization of a virtual coaching business, but their use is not mandatory. If the fitness professional decides to use a traditional analog scheduling system, it is imperative they stay on top of appointment confirmations, time-zone differences, appointment records, and session tracking. Great communication and organizational skills are a must for fitness professionals that choose to rely on traditional scheduling tools (e.g., pen and paper, calendar, phone calls, etc.).

Scheduling Options

Scheduling Modality	Pros	Cons
Online Scheduling Technology (e.g., Calendly, MeetFox, or SimplyBook.me)	• Fast • Efficient • Provides notifications and reminders • Accurate record-keeping	• Typically requires a fee
E-mails, Text Messages, and Phone Calls	• Cost-effective • Ease of use	• No notifications • Manual process • Increased likelihood of scheduling errors
Analog Calendar or Pen and Paper	• Cost-effective • Ease of use	• No notifications • Manual process

- Increased likelihood of errors and miscommunication
- Still requires the use of another modality to communicate schedule with the client

Confirming Appointments

Once a scheduling system is chosen, the fitness professional will need to determine which appointment confirmation system will best complement their business. Confirming appointments maximizes a fitness professional's time, minimizes missed appointments, and provides appointment reminders to clients. Using a virtual scheduling tool is an efficient method for managing appointments as these tools can be programmed to provide reminders at specific times prior to an appointment. An efficient confirmation system should notify a client about an upcoming appointment 12 to 24 hours prior to its start. This time frame provides the fitness professional with enough notice to adjust their schedule and the client with enough notice to reschedule without penalty. If the fitness professional chooses not to use a scheduling tool it is imperative that they keep track of upcoming appointments and confirm them with their clients via e-mail, text message, or phone call.



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The scheduling and confirming of appointments organizes and optimizes a virtual training business, but without **accountability structures** such as policies and signed agreements, issues of adherence may still come up. Designing and communicating a cancellation policy may aid in keeping clients and professionals accountable for their scheduled appointments.

A **cancellation policy** is a statement of the course of action to occur if an agreed-on meeting is not upheld in a predetermined manner or time frame. Cancellation policies are put in place to hold the client accountable to the agreed-on times of confirmed appointments. Additionally, a cancellation policy should allow the fitness professional enough time to fill the session should a client cancel. The penalty for failing to appear for a confirmed appointment could be as severe as a complete loss of a paid session, as mild as a small penalty fee, or a verbal warning. The cancellation policy must be determined by the fitness professional and should be clearly communicated to the client prior to engaging in the virtual training program. Cancellation policies are not intended to punish clients for mishaps. Rather, they are designed to encourage schedule integrity by providing appointment confirmation time constraints (e.g., 12 to 24 hours prior to the session or a 10-minute grace period). These confirmations not only hold participants accountable; they also act as helpful reminders and allow penalty-free margins for rescheduling.

Cancellation Policy Examples

Example Cancellation Policies

- A client can cancel or reschedule an appointment 12 hours prior to the session, penalty-free.
- A client can cancel or reschedule an appointment 24 hours prior to a session, penalty-free, and is allotted two no-shows prior to penalization.
- A client who fails to appear for a confirmed appointment will be penalized 100% of their session cost.
- A client who fails to appear for a confirmed appointment will be penalized 50% of their session cost.
- A client is allotted two no-shows prior to penalization. Once the client exceeds two no-shows, they will be penalized 100% of their session cost for any further missed appointments.
- A client is granted a 15-minute grace period at the beginning of each session. This means a client has a 15-minute window to appear for a session before being penalized.

Accountability structures

A framework outlining the terms or conditions of an agreement between two parties.

Cancellation policy

A statement or course of action to occur if an agreed-on meeting is not upheld in a predetermined manner or time frame.

Equipment Set-Up

Failing to check and prepare vital equipment prior to an appointment can drastically affect a virtual training business. If the fitness professional has a full week of scheduled appointments and their computer crashes, their audio or video system fails, or there is a loss of Internet connection, they will not only have a host of frustrated clients, but they may also lose future business. Fitness professionals should create an equipment checklist and go through the list at least 1 hour prior to the first appointment of each training day. Incorporating a daily equipment check routine will help mitigate any sudden or unexpected equipment breakdowns, allow time to rectify any issues that arise, and, if necessary, provide notice to scheduled clients.



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Once the fitness professional has completed their equipment check, they will need to set up all equipment required for their upcoming virtual coaching sessions. This includes but is not limited to computer and recording systems being fully charged and in place, having appropriate lighting set up, ensuring all required training equipment is accessible, and that training programs are completed and accessible. It is also best practice for the fitness professional to perform an end-of-day checklist to account for any equipment that will need to be fully charged, cleaned, or turned off after each day of appointments.

Equipment Preparation Checklist

❏ Camera and audio recording system functioning properly

❏ Computer connected and functioning as expected

❏ All battery-powered peripherals fully charged

❏ Lighting systems on and functioning

❏ All required training equipment accessible

❏ Client workout program(s) complete and ready to access

End-of-Day Checklist

❏ Electronic equipment that requires a charge (e.g., computers, cameras, or batteries) set to charge before the next day of appointments

❏ Electronic equipment that does not require a charge (e.g. external lighting) unplugged from the power source until the next day of appointments

❏ Training equipment and environment cleaned and arranged in an appropriate location for the next day of appointments

Program and Session Preparation

To maintain a successful virtual training business, the fitness professional should be prepared prior to the start of each and every session. A training session that is void of a predetermined training program or structure can lead to a multitude of complications. The fitness professional might forget what the client's workout is on a particular day or accidentally confuse one client's program for another's. By completing the design and planning of each client's program and having it accessible prior to their session, the fitness professional can mitigate the likelihood of these complications. The saying, "failing to plan is planning to fail," is a good reminder for fitness professionals engaging with clients in the virtual environment. Preparing training programs prior to a session provides a foundation and structure from which the fitness professional can make intelligent and effective alterations when necessary (**Figure: Preparation**).



FigurePreparation

Once the information is gathered from initial assessments, such as health and injury history, client limitations and preference, and physical assessments, the fitness professional will construct a training program for their client based on their individual goals. The fitness professional can utilize a variety of online training program builders, such as NASM EDGE, or choose to use something as simple as a spreadsheet program (e.g., Microsoft Excel, Google Sheets, etc.) or even pen and paper. Once developed, the training programs should be organized in such a way that they will be easy to track, record, and adjust when necessary.



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Regardless of which program development tool the fitness professional chooses to use, it is vital they have easy access to the programs prior to each virtual training session. Having training programs completed and accessible prior to appointments will mitigate complications and ensure program integrity during training sessions. As mentioned previously, a client's program may need to be adjusted or altered at times, but having everything prepared and accessible will help the fitness professional make the most effective adjustments.

Training Environment



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To effectively implement virtual training sessions, the fitness professional will need an appropriate amount of space and a suitable environment. Virtual training clients watch and listen to movements and exercise cues as their only source of coaching. So, having adequate space and the environment to perform and instruct exercise movements is paramount. The client does not want to see their trainer struggling to direct the session due to a lack of organization or space.

Critical!

Fitness professionals engaging in virtual training should make the following training environment considerations:

- Does the space have enough room to not only demonstrate exercises but also include enough space for the filming system to capture the entire body and movement demonstration in the frame?
- What camera angle is most suitable for the training session or exercise selection?
- What external sounds could the space be exposed to? Is the appropriate equipment available to mitigate any potential sound interruptions?
- What kind of lighting (fluorescent, skylight, natural light, etc.) does the space have? Is there a skylight or natural light? Will the time of day a session is conducted be a factor? Will the fitness professional need extra lighting equipment?
- What kind of flooring does the space have? Carpet? Hardwood? Tile? Gym flooring? Will the flooring be a hindrance to the style of the training session?
- Does the space have enough room for all the necessary training equipment?

Spacing

The fitness professional should first consider what style of movements they will be consistently demonstrating in their sessions. Perhaps the movements will be primarily dynamic, high-intensity exercises like plyometrics, or maybe the exercises will consist mostly of easy, restorative movements that are performed in a single location. Once the fitness professional has determined the training style to use, they should perform a practice run of a few of the primary exercises. The practice run is intended to

ensure there is ample space for safe demonstration of the exercises, void of obstacles. If space limitations do exist, the fitness professional will need to make alterations to either the movement and exercise selection or the training space itself (e.g., not jumping as high or moving a coffee table).

Filming

Once the practice run is complete and the training space is adjusted to complete all movement, the fitness professional should film some of the primary exercises and ensure that the chosen camera or filming system is able to capture each movement in its entirety. Optimal placement for a filming system is 6 to 8 feet from the camera. Depending on the filming method (phone, computer, external camera), this distance may have to be adjusted.

Another vital aspect of camera placement is the camera angle. The camera angle must provide the most optimal viewing experience to the client. Determining which perspective will allow the viewer to see the most important aspects of exercise form is an effective way to choose a camera angle. The camera angle not only shapes a client's viewing experience but may even mold client perceptions of their instructor. Camera angles have even been suggested to affect viewer perception of trustworthiness.



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In a 2017 study, camera angles positioned at eye-level (**Figure: Camera Angles**) were shown to have positive effects on viewer perceptions of trustworthiness, in comparison to upward or downward camera angles (Baranowski & Hecht, 2017).



FigureCamera Angles

The fitness professional may choose to demonstrate exercises facing the camera, positioned perpendicularly to the camera, or from multiple positions. By filming a few of the primary exercises from the chosen angle and reviewing the footage, the fitness professional will be able to assess whether the viewer will be able to determine and replicate the exercises demonstrated (**Figure: Straight-On and Downward Camera Angles**). Exercises that are stationary or that occur in the sagittal/frontal plane will benefit from a straight-on or balanced camera view with no angle. Dynamic, non-conventional, or transverse plane exercises will benefit from a slightly angled (up or down) camera position to provide a more comprehensive view of the movements. Once the fitness professional has filmed a few of their primary exercises and reviewed the footage, they will be able to make necessary adjustments to their camera angle and spacing.



FigureStraight-On and Downward Camera Angles

Sound and Audio



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Administering virtual training is highly reliant on verbal cues and coaching. The fitness professional will not physically be with the client to spot them or make form adjustments. So, the client's ability to clearly hear and understand the coach becomes vital. The fitness professional should consider investing in a shotgun or lavalier mic to achieve quality audio. While setting up the training environment, the fitness professional should assess potential external sounds that might disrupt a training session. If the training space is in an apartment, adjacent to a noisy freeway, or exposed to children or pets, precautions need to be taken to mitigate the likelihood of those sounds impacting the training session.

Soundproofing supplies such as foam soundproofing panels, blackout or noise reduction curtains, and carpets/rugs are cost-effective methods for absorbing unwanted external noise vibrations.

Investing in soundproofing materials can transform an unsuitable training environment into a calm, quiet space perfect for virtual training implementation. If the fitness professional has children, pets, or roommates, they should make necessary arrangements and schedule specific times to do their filming and training sessions.

Lighting

Lighting in a virtual training environment can make the difference between an enjoyable, effortless viewing experience or a frustrating viewing experience. Poor lighting conditions might complicate a client's view and make it difficult to comprehend exercises and instructions. The fitness professional should assess the lighting in their training space prior to filming and make all necessary adjustments until they are certain the viewer has no trouble seeing the instructor in the frame. Lighting in a building can vary greatly. Some rooms are lit through natural light by way of windows, some from skylights, and some from various artificial lights at different angles.

If natural light beaming through windows or skylights is the primary light source of the space, the fitness professional will need to evaluate the times of day they will be filming or performing training sessions. Filming exercise videos or performing training sessions as the sun sets may provide a poor experience for the client.



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The time of day the filming will be performed (e.g., sunrise, midday, or sunset) will also need to be considered. Ideally, the fitness professional should pick times when it is brightest in the room to be filming or administering training sessions. Filming a practice video or performing a mock training session can help the fitness professional determine if natural lighting is adequate for their needs. When evaluating lighting, the main goal is to ensure that the fitness professional and the exercises being performed can be properly viewed and are undistorted to the camera. If the lighting is such that it casts a shadow on the fitness professional or over-illuminates them, adjustments will need to be made to the camera position or the time of day the filming is performed, or artificial lighting equipment may be needed.

If artificial lighting is required, the fitness professional will need to consider both the lighting angle and power (wattage). The lights will need to be positioned so that they do not complicate camera function or instructor visibility. Lights that are aimed directly at a camera or shining from the opposing side of the camera and instructor can distort the client's view. Artificial lights will also need to be powerful or bright enough to illuminate the entire body of the fitness professional. Purchasing dimmable lights will give the fitness professional more adjustability for setting up their environment. Lighting that shines from behind or to one side of the camera onto the instructor is not optimal, so additional lights may need to be acquired (**Figure: Example Lighting and Camera Set-Up**). Lighting systems designed for photoshoots are recommended for additional artificial lighting. Ring lights, clip-on phone lights, or even a house-hold lamp with the shade removed can provide adequate lighting for those with a lower-budget.



FigureExample Lighting and Camera Set-Up

Exercise Area



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The style of flooring in a virtual training environment will affect the exercise and footwear selection for the fitness professional. Flooring surfaces can vary from hardwood and tile to carpet and rugs. If the training space contains slick flooring, such as tile, linoleum, or hardwood, the fitness professional will need to make sure they wear appropriate footwear during their sessions. Conducting sessions in shoes with worn soles or while in socks is ill-advised on slick surfaces as accidents and movement complications may be more likely to occur. If the space contains rugs or has a carpeted surface, the fitness professional may need to put less thought into footwear. Some longer carpets like shag-style carpet can be slick. Slick carpeting may cause trouble gaining traction and increase injury risk while in footwear with worn soles or insufficient ankle support. The fitness professional should test the movements being performed beforehand and determine footwear requirements.

Another aspect of flooring that warrants consideration is visibility. If the flooring is distracting or complicates the client's ability to see the instructor’s extremities or equipment placement, adjustments will need to be made. These might include adjustments to the exercise selection or flooring type to provide an optimal viewing experience for the client. Additional flooring adjustments that can be made to optimize the client’s experience include laying down solid-colored, low-profile rugs, using foam or rubberized mats, and coaching on flooring void of shag-style carpeting and potentially distracting graphics or patterns. Adjustments to exercise selection are dependent on the flooring available. If the flooring is hard (e.g., hardwood, tile, or linoleum) the viewer is not likely to have trouble seeing the placement of extremities (e.g. hand placement or foot placement), whereas, thick rugs and shag-style carpeting may complicate a viewer’s understanding of proper placement of extremities (e.g., foot placement in a squatting exercise) and exercise selection will need to be adjusted.

Once the flooring in the space has been assessed and adjusted for functionality, the fitness professional will need to ensure that their training equipment will not affect or be affected by the flooring material. Heavier training equipment such as dumbbells, kettlebells, or any weighted object will not distort the viewer’s experience, but they may have an impact on the flooring in the space. Hardwood, linoleum, and tile surfaces can be damaged and cause the camera to shake if a piece of equipment is dropped. If the flooring surface is at risk of damage or rattles the camera when it hits the floor, the fitness professional

should place a suitable floor covering such as a rug or rubber mat over the area where training sessions will occur. Rubber training mats and thick rugs are sufficient for absorbing vibration and protecting flooring from damage.

If the fitness professional is choosing exercises that involve equipment such as foam rollers, exercise sliders, or an exercise ball, they must test the flooring surface to ensure the exercise movement is not restricted. For example, utilizing an exercise ball on a carpeted area may increase the risk of the ball sliding out.

Environment Safety Considerations

Fitness professionals should also inform clients about best practices regarding flooring safety when exercising. Slick flooring, such as hardwood, tile, and linoleum floors, can be dangerous surfaces to perform lateral, jumping, or explosive movements on, especially in improper footwear. If the client is wearing footwear with minimal traction (for example, socks), slick floors are appropriate for performing gliding or sliding movements such as a mountain climber exercise. However, if the client were to attempt a plyometric or explosive lateral movement in just their socks, there would be a higher risk for the client slipping and getting injured. The fitness professional should educate their clients on appropriate footwear and adjust the exercise selections when their flooring poses a potential injury risk.

Presentation

The cleanliness and appearance of the training environment may not seem important in a virtual setting, but it can have a significant impact on the fitness professional's business. Additionally, the way in which professionals present themselves, whether it be online or in-person, speaks volumes about their competence and professionalism. If a client were to book an online appointment with a telehealth provider, an attorney, or even just engage in a business meeting, they would expect a professional environment and presentation. If the professional were to conduct their session in a space with dirty laundry on the floor, empty pizza boxes on the table, and trash cans piled to the top, the client would likely form unwanted opinions about their professionalism.

Presenting to clients in a clean, clutter-free, and organized space goes a long way in demonstrating competence. This also displays a courtesy to clients and conveys that the professional takes their business and the client's time seriously.

Virtual training may require relocation to a new space, whether it be due to traveling or renting a new training space. Regardless of where a fitness professional is conducting their training sessions, they should make their best effort to keep the space as clean and organized as possible. This is not to suggest that remodeling and reconstruction are necessary. The primary objective of the fitness professional should be to do their best to keep the space they operate in as orderly and clean as possible. Fitness professionals may consider completing a cleaning checklist prior to filming or video conferencing.



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Helpful Hint

Training Environment Cleaning Checklist

❏ Walls/Curtains: Remove any posters, art, or markings on the wall that could be distracting or potentially offensive. Ensure walls and curtains are free of holes.

❏ Windows: Any windows that are visible to the client should be clean and streak-free.

❏ Floor: The floors should be clean and free of dirt, debris, garbage, or clothing.

❏ Furniture: If there is any furniture in the space (e.g., couch, coffee table, or chairs), it should be free of any garbage or unnecessary items. Furniture should be kept in an organized and orderly fashion when possible.

❏ Garbage: All garbage and garbage bins should be completely removed and out of view while filming exercise videos, performing virtual coaching sessions, or during video calls.

Professional Appearance and Attire

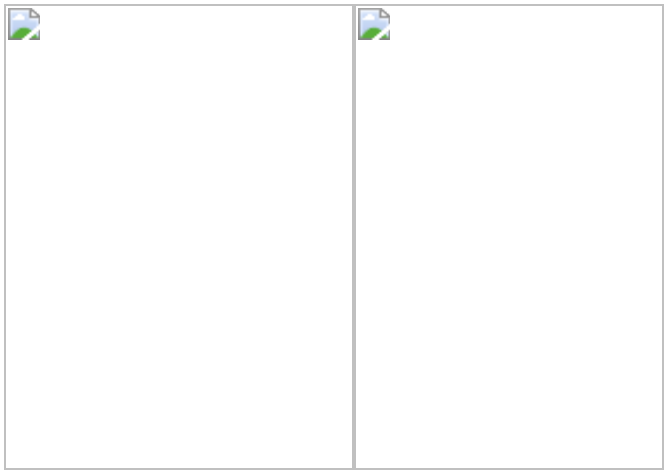
In the same way that a virtual training environment demonstrates professionalism, so does personal presentation. A 2018 study on the effect's appearance had on professionalism showed that health care professionals who took the time to improve their appearance were perceived as more professional and trustworthy (Wills et al., 2018). The fitness professional will not need to conduct virtual training sessions in dress attire but presenting in clean and appropriate clothing displays professionalism and competence. Basic training attire is all that is necessary for a fitness professional operating in a virtual training environment. Ensuring the attire is free of stains, holes, wrinkles, and offensive or distracting graphics will strengthen the professional's presentation.

Helpful Hint

Recommended Virtual Training Attire

- Solid color t-shirts or tank tops
- Solid color shorts or training pants
- Comfortable, appropriate (based on session type and flooring) athletic shoes

(See **Figures Below: Recommended Virtual Training Attire**)

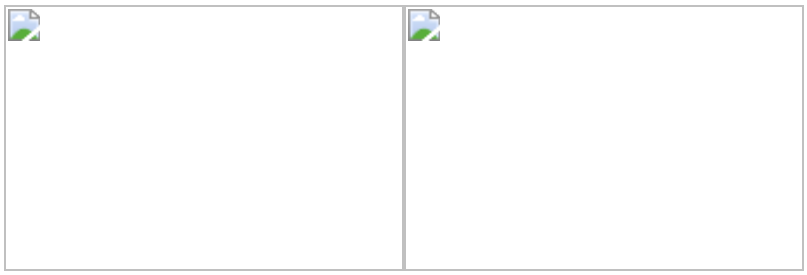


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Virtual Training Attire to Avoid

- Potentially offensive graphic t-shirts or pants
- Clothes with noticeable holes or stains
- Distracting accessories (e.g., large bracelets, necklaces, or earrings)

(See **Figures Below: Virtual Training Attire to Avoid**)



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Virtual training environment and physical appearance are the components that shape the professional's virtual presence. Taking the time to go through each aspect of the training environment will not only ensure the professional conducts safe and efficient virtual training sessions, but it will also convey a message of courtesy, professionalism, knowledge, and competence.

Equipment Access for the Fitness Professional



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Equipment access is a primary limitation of virtual when compared to in-person training. When a fitness professional works at a gym, they may have unlimited access to workout equipment, whereas, when at home or running a smaller virtual coaching business, equipment access may be limited. When considering workout programming, the exercises chosen for the client are more dependent on what type of equipment the client has versus what equipment the trainer has on hand. This is because the trainer can still demonstrate many movements without specifically having those machines or extra equipment available. This is also where filming exercise videos to use as demonstrations when writing client programming can help minimize the equipment needed when performing the virtual coaching sessions themselves. Ideally, the fitness professional should have some basic equipment available to demonstrate movements and show proper form. Dumbbells or resistance bands generally suffice; the fitness professional does not need a full gym worth of equipment to administer a quality training session.

Client Equipment Purchasing

Client equipment access will be the primary consideration when selecting appropriate exercises. Programming should consider what equipment the client has available so that the fitness professional is prepared with an appropriate exercise program design. The client and fitness professional do not need to have matching equipment. For instance, the client may use a dumbbell for a goblet squat, while the trainer uses a kettlebell. Small changeups like this mid-session will be easily managed. Client equipment requirements may also be dependent on goals. If a client is trying to build as much strength as possible, or maximize muscle growth, working out at home with a set of 5-pound dumbbells and resistance bands may not provide the adequate loading required for those goals. If the client is looking to move better and feel better and does not have specific performance goals, a small selection of bands or dumbbells will suffice.

The most efficient way to determine what equipment will be needed for a training session is for the fitness professional to ask their client what their goals are, where the client will be training (at home or at a gym), and what equipment they will have access to. It is up to the fitness professional to educate the client on equipment requirements. To make the best use of virtual coaching sessions, **Table: Basic Virtual Training Equipment Recommendations** highlights some basic equipment recommendations.

Basic Virtual Training Equipment Recommendations

- A range of kettlebells from 3 to 30 lbs depending on skill levels
- A range of dumbbells from 3 to 40 lbs, or adjustable dumbbells such as PowerBlocks or SelectTechs – This will vary based on skill and budget
- A workout bench that adjusts from flat to incline or decline
- An exercise/stability ball will also suffice for many exercises performed on a bench
- A high-quality set of resistance bands of varying resistance-levels, with a door anchor kit
- Some extra equipment to consider:
    - A variety of medicine balls
    - Foam roller or lacrosse ball for mobility work
    - A pull-up bar
    - Suspension training
    - Stretching/exercise mat

The equipment listed in **Table: Basic Virtual Training Equipment Recommendations** represents basic training equipment recommendations, not mandatory equipment requirements. Clients may have access to a wider variety of equipment (e.g., barbells or treadmills) or they may have access to only a few select pieces of equipment. There are many factors that may affect a client's training equipment access, from budget to physical capacity. There may be scenarios in which a client does not have access to any training equipment at all. They may not currently have a budget for purchasing new equipment or they may be traveling and lack access to equipment. In these scenarios, the fitness professional may need to adjust their training programs to best suit clients' needs and given equipment. Bands can be easily packed in a suitcase or carry-on bags for clients on the go.



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When equipment is lacking, the fitness professional can utilize objects in the client's surroundings to modify exercises and training sessions. Integrating a client's surroundings into their training session can make up for the lack of equipment by substituting gravity and the client's own body weight for resistance. Objects such as stairs, chairs, a sturdy table, canned goods, or water or milk jugs can turn a space void of equipment into a miniature gym. Developing creative ways to safely integrate a client's surroundings can not only make up for an equipment deficiency but also make workouts fun and engaging.

Critical!

Because the virtual fitness professional is most likely instructing their clients to perform exercises in their own home environment, it is imperative that the fitness professional do so safely and rationally. Exercises that place a client in a dangerous position, near a potentially unsafe object, or on a questionable surface should be avoided at all costs (e.g., pull-ups from a high elevation or exercises on glass tables or near sharp objects). The fitness professional should learn about the client's fitness environment and prescribe exercises using rational thinking and with safety in mind.

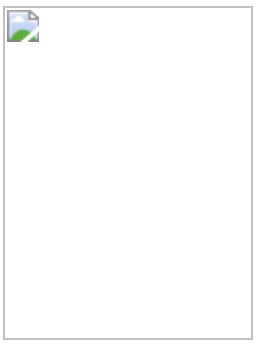
Try This

Practice using these household objects and surroundings to perform safer, less-risky exercise variations.

- **Couch**: Box Squat, Rear Foot Elevated Split Squat, and Decline Push-Up
- **Chairs**: Tricep Dip, Deficit Push-Up, and Chair-Supported Single-Leg Squat
- **Slick Flooring** (hardwood, tile, or linoleum): Mountain Climbers, Pike-Up, and Ab Roll Out
- **Stairs**: Toe Taps, Step-Ups, Calf Raise, and Conditioning



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Client Instruction and Virtual Communication Strategies

Effective communication is an important aspect of a successful virtual training session. Clients engaging in a virtual training program will be relying on the communication and instructional skills of the fitness professional conducting their session. Fitness professionals need to be able to effectively instruct, coach, and motivate clients with little more than their voice and movement. Virtual clients will be able to see and hear their instructor performing exercises, but effective training sessions also require detailed coaching, demonstration, and preparation. The ability to prepare for, communicate with, and instruct clients whom the professional may never be in the same room with is what sets great virtual fitness professionals apart from mediocre ones.

Workout and Session Structure

When designing a training program for a client, outlining and organizing the training sessions creates a road map the fitness professional will use to help their clients get to their destination. In the virtual training environment, clients will be faced with multiple variables that could alter their training programs. Equipment access, training frequency, training duration, and missed appointments are all aspects that will alter the structure of a training program from client to client. The objective is to get the client from Point A to Point B in the safest, most effective, and efficient manner possible. Many obstacles may arise along the way, but as mentioned previously, designing a plan prior to starting will help to mitigate complications during the journey. This may mean the fitness professional must adapt quickly to a busy client's changing needs.

The organization of workouts may be dictated by several factors such as equipment availability, training intensity, and training frequency. Whatever the case may be, the fitness professional should organize workouts based on the needs of their clients and utilize a system to keep track of which workouts will be scheduled and when. Organizing and keeping track of workouts will aid in keeping clients on track to obtain their goals and increase training program efficacy.

Program Planning



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Organizing workouts for virtual training clients could be as simple as determining what style of training they will do throughout the week (**Figure: Sample Training Program**). For example, if training 3 days per week on a Monday, Wednesday, and Friday, the structure could be Monday: Resistance Training, Wednesday: Aerobic Conditioning, and Friday: HIIT. Program planning could also be more involved where periodization strategies are used to achieve specific monthly training goals in order to obtain peak physical condition by a specific date (e.g., Month 1: Hypertrophy, Month 2: Strength, and Month 3: Power). The primary goal of planning and organizing client programs should be to allow the fitness professional to keep track of workouts and alter them over time. Altering workouts each session, even slightly, can help improve client adherence. Engaging in the same workouts every session can lead to client boredom. When clients perform new or different workouts in each session, they are more likely to enjoy their training and adhere to the program. The organization of workouts may be dictated by several factors such as equipment availability, training intensity, and training frequency. Whatever the case may be, the fitness professional should organize workouts based on the needs of their clients and utilize a system to keep track of which workouts will be scheduled and when. Organizing and keeping track of workouts will aid in keeping clients on track to obtain their goals and increase training program efficacy.



FigureSample Training Program

Visual and Verbal Instruction

The most vital aspect of virtual training is effective instruction. Without the luxury of in-person communication, where a trainer and client can clearly see and hear each other, it is imperative for the fitness professional to execute clear and concise visual and verbal instruction to their clients.

As mentioned earlier in this chapter, sound checks and camera positioning will need to be tested and adjusted to ensure all demonstrations are visible and instructions audible for the chosen recording device. Anything in the space that is obstructing or distorting the view or audio of the instruction will need to be removed or adjusted. Once a thorough sound and camera check have been completed, the fitness professional can then focus on the delivery of their instructions.

Verbal instructions should be clear and easy to understand. The fitness professional should speak at an appropriate volume and enunciate as they speak.



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It is also best to limit fitness jargon and complex instructions that could potentially confuse a client. For example, while describing a squatting exercise, the fitness professional would clearly and concisely verbalize the most important aspects of the exercise and avoid describing the exercise in complex or confusing language.

Visual instructions should be provided using proper form, a demonstrative pace, and by performing multiple repetitions of the exercise being shown. For example, while demonstrating a push-up for a client, the instructor will slowly perform multiple repetitions using proper form. By speaking clearly in a language and tone the client can easily interpret and by demonstrating in such a way that the client can easily determine what they should be doing, the fitness professional will be providing their clients with the best opportunity to understand the instruction.

Coach's Corner

Example verbal Instructions for a squat exercise:

Clear and Concise: “Squat down like you are sitting into a chair and put your weight through the center of your feet as you stand back up.”

Complex and Confusing: “Squat down until your hips reach parallel while maintaining thoracic extension. Once parallel has been reached, press through your heels, squeeze your glutes, and bring yourself into hip extension.”

Try This

The fitness professional may consider the following example of instruction

“If you watch my elbows, they aren’t flaring out and making me shaped like a *T*, but, rather, they are tucked back slightly as if I’m trying to hold a tennis ball in my armpit.”

Pre-, Intra-, and Post-Session Instruction

Before conducting a training session, the fitness professional should determine which style of instruction is best suited for the specific workout and/or their specific style of training. There are a few ways to effectively instruct a virtual training session: pre-, intra-, and post-session instruction.

Pre-Session Instruction

Pre-session instruction is the act of demonstrating or describing the components of an individual workout session or exercise routine prior to beginning the session. This may include demonstrating each individual exercise in the routine, going over all important details, or describing duration, intervals, and intensity levels. Pre-session instruction is best used for fast-paced, high-intensity style training routines. During fast-paced routines, there is not much time available for detailed instruction during the workout itself. By providing instruction or demonstration prior to this type of workout, the instructor allows the client to perform the routine without interruption and allows the fitness professional to have the opportunity to coach, motivate, and make minor corrections.

Helpful Hint

Pre-session instruction is best suited for the following activities:

- Pre-recorded workouts
- Group fitness settings
- Circuits
- HIIT training
- Time-based intervals



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Coach’s Corner

The following is an example of pre-session instructions:

Session Information: A fitness professional has designed a Tabata/interval-inspired workout for their client to complete. The client is to perform 20 seconds of high-intensity work followed by 10 seconds of rest using four different exercises:

1. Squat Jump
2. Push-Up

3. Lunge Jump
4. Dumbbell Squat to Overhead Press

Pre-Session Instructions: Prior to starting the workout, the fitness professional takes time to explain the circuit, demonstrates each exercise, has the client perform each exercise, and provides them with exercise cues. If the instructor were to provide instructions during the routine or in the 10-second rest period, they understand that they would likely disrupt the training intensity, work intervals, and even the client's focus.

Pre-session instruction

The act of demonstrating or describing the components of an individual workout session or exercise routine prior to beginning the session.

Intra- and Post-Session Instruction

Intra- and/or post-session instruction is a form of instruction that consists of a demonstration or correction of training variables during and/or after a training session or exercise bout. This form of instruction is useful when time or exercise complexity is not a limiting factor. This form of instruction may be most effective when a client is not performing a complex routine or has plenty of time to perform the reps and sets of their session.

Helpful Hint

Intra- and/or post-session instruction are best suited for the following activities:

- Low-intensity workouts
- Low-complexity workouts
- Familiar workouts
- Long-duration sets and workouts

If a client is performing an exercise for a long and continuous duration, for example, a 15-rep set of goblet squats, there is plenty of time for the fitness professional to coach the client and make form corrections along the way. A brief pre-session instruction could be utilized in conjunction with intra-/post-session instruction, but taking time to provide pre-session instruction could potentially take away from the time spent engaging in the actual session in a continuous, long-duration routine.

Coach's Corner

The following is an example of intra-/post-session instructions.

A client is scheduled to perform a simple exercise in which technique is not a major concern such as goblet squats. The client is going to do the exercise for three sets of 12 to 15 reps. Goblet squats are a simple exercise that may not require much coaching or form correction. Rather than taking time away from the session by demonstrating and explaining the exercise in detail, the fitness professional can have the client perform the squats. If any necessary corrections are needed, the fitness professional understands there will be plenty of time to correct them during those sets without impacting the training session.

Intra-session instruction

A form of instruction that consists of demonstration or correction of training variables during a training session or exercise bout.

Post-session instruction

A form of instruction that consists of demonstration or correction of training variables after a training session or exercise bout.

Cueing Exercise Techniques

An **exercise cue** is a condensed or simplified version of instructions used to help clients more easily understand or achieve a training or exercise objective. Providing exercise cues to a client during a training session is an effective coaching tactic. Cues can be as simple as instructing a client to drive their hips back or as creative as telling them to try to spread the floor with their feet. In the virtual training environment, because efficiency is of the essence, cues serve as a fantastic coaching tool. Simply instructing a client to squat may not be a sufficient form of instruction and going into great detail about each aspect of an exercise may cause frustration and confusion for clients.

Exercise cues bridge the gap between understanding and implementation. A training client will need to understand the primary components of an exercise in a time-efficient and easy-to-comprehend manner. The fitness professional will not need an exhaustive list of cues for every exercise, but it is beneficial to develop some cues for the exercises that are utilized in programs. These cues can also be used to help clients gauge exercise or training difficulty. Providing a cue or scale for intensity to help guide and quantify client training intensity can serve as a more effective method than using more complex instructions such as “74% of 1RM” (Sweet et al., 2004).

A **rating of perceived exertion (RPE)** scale is a number-based scale used to gauge the level of exertion or difficulty of an act or event (**Figure: RPE Scale**). An RPE scale can be used by a fitness professional to easily prescribe an intensity level to perform an exercise at and by a client to comprehend and communicate difficulty levels.



FigureRPE Scale

Exercise cue

A condensed or simplified version of instruction used to help an individual more easily understand or achieve a training or exercise objective.

Rating of perceived exertion (RPE)

A number-based scale used to gauge the level of exertion or difficulty of an act or event.

Cueing for exercises should highlight the most important or difficult-to-comprehend aspects of an exercise. The fitness professional should consider how they might explain the exercise to a child (**Figure: Cueing**). For instance, while coaching a child to squat, a person would not say, “Keep the torso erect, press the hips back while bending at the knees, track the knees over the midfoot, and, once 90 degrees of depth is achieved, press through your heels, squeeze the glutes, and return to the start position.” A child is more likely to comprehend a short, simple instruction that accomplishes a similar goal such as, “Keep the chest up proud, push the rear back like you’re sitting into a chair, and stand back up.” While simple and concise language is needed, talking down to a client should also be avoided.

Corrections will always need to be made by the fitness professional, but using simple, effective cues will save time, effort, and frustration for both the professional trainer and client.



FigureCueing
Coach's Corner

The following are examples of exercise cues for primary movements:

Bodyweight Squat:

- “Drive your butt back like you are sitting into a chair.”
- “Lift your chest up tall and proud.”
- “Drive your knees away from each other.”
- “Screw your feet into the floor.”
- “Press the floor away from you.”

Push-Up:

- “Pull your belly button back to your spine.”
- “Imagine you are a stiff board from head to heel.”
- “Push the floor away from you.”

Bent Over Row:

- “Unlock your knees and hinge at the waist.”
- “Imagine a string is pulling your elbows straight up toward the ceiling.”
- “Keep your back flat; imagine your spine is a stiff pole.”

Exercise Selection

Proper exercise selection is not exclusive to virtual training, but it warrants consideration due to potential equipment barriers. Preparing exercise programs and selecting exercises based on a client's equipment and space allows for quicker, more efficient adjustments to be made when needed. If the fitness professional does not know what equipment their client will have access to, they should incorporate movement patterns that could easily be performed both weighted or unweighted, with only minor alterations. By choosing exercises in this fashion, the fitness professional will avoid having to make drastic training program changes in real time if their client lacks the necessary equipment. Variables such as sets, reps, tempo, and rest periods can always be adjusted to increase training difficulty when an exercise that is intended to be performed with external resistance now has to be performed with just bodyweight.



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Food for Thought

Here are some considerations for adjusting training difficulty and intensity:

- **Repetitions**: Goal dependence – Increase the number of repetitions in each set.
- **Sets**: Increase the total number of sets being performed of a specific movement.
- **Antagonistic Supersets**: Complete sets of antagonistic exercises back to back with minimal to no rest in between sets. For example, performing a lat-pull down followed by a chest fly. The pull-down is a pulling exercise and the chest fly is a pushing exercise.
- **Agonistic Supersets (Compound Sets):** Performing similar movements for the same muscle group(s) back to back to create additional stimulus or stress – For example, performing a chest fly and then doing push-ups right after
- **Tempo or Time Under Tension**: Increase time under tension or increase the tempo of sets and repetitions. An example of this is the 2-1-2 model outline in **Table: Loaded Versus Unloaded Exercise Adjustment Examples**: 2-1-2 = 2 seconds in the eccentric or lowering phase, 1 second in the isometric or static phase, and 2 seconds in the concentric or lifting phase.
- **Rest Periods**: Decrease rest time between sets or include an active rest period in which the client is instructed to perform a low-intensity activity during prescribed rest times.

Loaded Versus Unloaded Exercise Adjustment Examples

Squat Exercise

- Loaded: Dumbbell Squat – 3 x 10, Rest Period: 60 seconds
- Unloaded: Tempo Squat (2-0-2) – 4 x 8, Rest Period: 45 seconds

(2-0-2 = 2 seconds in the eccentric or lowering phase, 0 seconds in the isometric or static phase, and 2 seconds in the concentric or upward phase.)

Horizontal Pressing Exercise

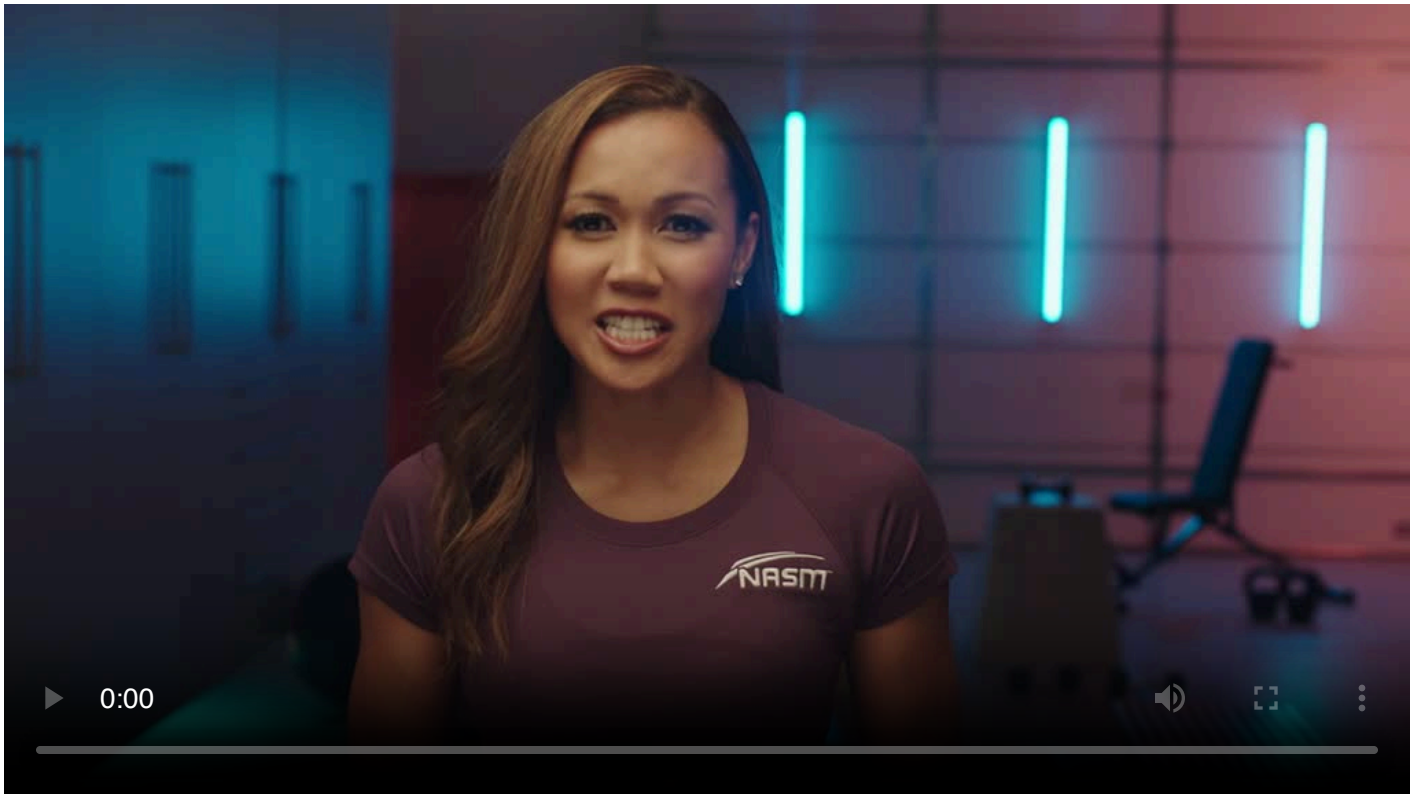
- Loaded: Dumbbell Bench Press – 3 x 10, Rest Period: 60 seconds
- Unloaded: Tempo Push-Up (2-1-2) – 4 x 8, Rest Period: 45 seconds

(2-1-2 = 2 seconds in the eccentric or lowering phase, 1 second in the isometric or static phase, and 2 seconds in the concentric or upward phase.)

Lunge Exercise

- Loaded: Dumbbell Forward Lunge – 3 x 10, Rest Period: 60 seconds
- Unloaded: Tempo Rear Foot Elevated Split Squat (2-1-2) – 4 x 8, Rest Period: 45 seconds

(2-1-2 = 2 seconds in the eccentric or lowering phase, 1 second in the isometric or static phase, and 2 seconds in the concentric or upward phase.)



NASM VCS Lecture CH6

Small or Large Group Training



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Virtual training may take place in a small (2 to 10 individuals) or large (10 or more individuals) group setting. Clients will be engaged in a class receiving live instruction from a fitness professional, watching a prerecorded video of a fitness professional conducting a training session, or following along to a live stream group workout. In the group fitness setting, the fitness professional will often lack the resources to focus on minor details and the sessions will tend to be more of a one-size-fits-all general fitness workout. The fitness professional should consider how each movement may be modified and regressed to suit a variety of skill levels and physical abilities among clients. During group training, the fitness professional should focus on the tone, delivery, and style of instruction provided.

Group Communication

The way in which the fitness professional communicates with and instructs clients in the group fitness setting directly affects the outcome of the class. Online group fitness classes may consist of multiple clients relying on just one or many fitness professionals for instruction. The classes may either be pre-recorded, live-interactive, or live-non-interactive (**Figure: Group Fitness**). In pre-recorded classes the fitness professional films a workout that is to be watched and completed by a class at a later date. In this virtual format, the class participants will have no access to the fitness professional during the class.



FigureGroup Fitness

Ensuring regressions and progressions of each movement being performed is key to engage clients of all fitness levels. A live-interactive group fitness class will consist of the fitness professional coaching a small or large group class in real time while watching and interacting with the participants. A live-non-interactive class (e.g., live-streaming) is similar to a prerecorded class, only the fitness professional conducts the training session live, at the same time as their class, but without visual access to the class.

Pre-Recorded Group Fitness Coaching

Pre-recorded group fitness classes require the fitness professional to be clear and concise with instructions as there will be no opportunity for correction or adjustments. Providing instruction on exercise technique and workout objectives multiple times during a pre-recorded group fitness class will help alleviate confusion and difficulties for the class. Providing detailed instruction on objectives, tempo, and exercise form prior to beginning the class is the most effective method for mitigating obstacles for participants in pre-recorded group fitness classes.

Helpful Hint

Key Components: Pre-Recorded and Group Fitness Coaching Key

- Provide clear, concise instructions.
- Repeat instructions multiple times.
- Provide instruction often, prior to and during the class.

Live Group Fitness Coaching

In live group fitness classes, fitness professionals should communicate clearly and concisely. If the fitness professional is coaching a live class in which they will be interacting with clients, they should avoid coaching in a way that purposefully singles out or isolates any participants. The coaching should be catered to the group and void of any form of favoritism or divisive language. All individual corrections and coaching provided should be for the sole purpose of motivation, education, and safety. Live-stream group classes, in which the fitness professional cannot interact with or see clients. should include multiple instructions provided often during the class, similar to pre-recorded group fitness classes.

Helpful Hint

Key Components: Live-Non-Interactive Group Fitness Coaching

- Provide clear, concise instructions.
- Repeat instructions multiple times.
- Provide instruction often, prior to and during the class.

Interactive live group fitness classes allow the fitness professional to make adjustments and corrections in real time, but class size may limit the amount of individual attention given to each participant. While coaching a small group fitness class, the instructor will be able to make regular adjustments without affecting class flow and effectiveness. However, this may not be the case in larger class sizes. Large group fitness classes may contain too many clients for the fitness professional to make consistent and individualized corrections. Coaching large group fitness classes in real time should be aimed at guiding the class as a group using outcome goals and generalized themes and should limit detailed corrections.

Helpful Hint

Key Components: Live-Interactive Group Fitness Coaching

- Provide clear, concise instructions.
- Limit frequency of detailed corrections.
- Keep coaching themes general and goal-oriented (avoid singling out clients).

Communication Tone

The tone and delivery of the instruction should reflect the intent or purpose of a group fitness class. The tone of the fitness professional should be uplifting, motivational, and function-focused. A 2018 study found that **function-focused coaching** had more positive effects on client body-satisfaction than appearance-focused coaching (Engeln et al., 2018). **Appearance-focused coaching** emphasizes physical appearance as the coaching objective of the class, whereas function-focused coaching emphasizes physical effort and outcomes (**Figure: Communication Tone**).



FigureCommunication Tone

Online fitness classes range from restorative to high-intensity. If the class is high-intensity and difficult, the fitness professional will need to motivate, encourage, and maintain appropriate tempo in the class. Motivating clients in a high-intensity class setting will include consistent upbeat and energetic encouragement. A class that is designed to be restorative or low-intensity, such as a yoga class, will require the fitness professional to present with a softer, more mellow tone. The fitness professional is responsible for recognizing the objective of the class and choosing a suitable tone and delivery to correlate with that objective.

Function-focused coaching

Fitness coaching emphasizing physical effort and outcomes.

Appearance-focused coaching

Fitness coaching geared toward improvements to physical appearance.

Safety Considerations

It can be challenging to ensure client safety in a virtual training environment. Fitness professionals cannot spot a client in a virtual training session as they can in-person, they cannot help them into and out of positions, or even help them if they happen to get injured. Certain precautions need to be taken in virtual training to promote safety and mitigate the risk of injury.

Helpful Hint

Here are some helpful ways for fitness professionals to improve safety in the virtual training environment.

- Collection and understanding of client injury history, PAR-Q+, and physical capacity
- Demonstration of proper use of training equipment and exercise form
- Consistent focus, attention, and awareness on client
- Have the client show them the whole workout area on camera or with pictures to determine if any safety concerns exist.
- Select exercises and movements that are suitable for the client’s workout environment.

Physical Readiness and Injury History

Fitness professionals should never attempt to diagnose or treat any form of illness; however, they should develop an understanding of the physical readiness of their clients. By providing clients with readiness questionnaires and reviewing their injury history, the fitness professional will have a better understanding of any limitations a client may have. Developing programs and awareness around a client's physical readiness will help the fitness professional maintain a safe virtual training program and environment for their clients.

Previous injuries, health conditions, lifestyle habits, and work environment all provide vital information used for shaping individual programs. However, if a client presents with a serious medical or health condition, the fitness professional should refer them to an appropriate medical professional for clearance before participating in training or physical activity.

Critical!

Fitness professionals, who are not licensed medical professionals, should never attempt to diagnose, treat or prescribe for any form of disease, illness, or medical condition.

Equipment Safety

Equipment safety is a byproduct of proper fitness professional demonstration and exercise selection. Fitness professionals should demonstrate exercises that require equipment and request that their clients demonstrate competency before progressing with more complexity, intensity, or increased weight. This demonstration can be completed through video calls or through form videos sent via e-mail or direct message. Demonstration of competency is needed, especially when a client has never used a particular piece of equipment or done a specific exercise movement.

Aligning exercise selection with client needs and capabilities mitigates equipment-related injury risk. If selected exercises are safe and the client has demonstrated competency, progressing the client to more challenging movements, incorporating added equipment, increasing difficulty, or adding more resistance to the movements can be done safely. If the client has not shown proficiency in performing an exercise safely, keeping the client at a regressed version of the exercise may increase exercise safety overall and minimize the potential risk of equipment-related injuries.

Attention and Awareness

The last, but certainly not least, safety consideration is the fitness professional's level of focus, attention, and awareness. All other safety precautions taken may fall short if the professional lacks awareness and focus on their clients during virtual training sessions. This simple yet important component is the foundation for safety in virtual training. Fitness professionals should maintain complete focus on their clients for the duration of their training session. They should refrain from checking their phone, leaving the room, or having external conversations or activities during appointments. This is not only a major component of safety but of professionalism, as well.



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Critical!

Fitness Professionals should avoid the following during a virtual training session:

- Being on the phone
- Checking e-mails
- Leaving the room
- Engaging in external conversations or activities

Virtual Nutrition Coaching



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Online nutrition coaching is an emerging industry. For the client, having a virtual nutrition coach will mean they have more access to their nutrition coach via e-mail, messaging, or client management software. Virtual nutrition coaching may have higher weight loss and more favorable health outcomes than in-person coaching (Johnson et al., 2019) (**Figure: Nutrition Coaching**). Professionals may find virtual nutrition coaching to be more desirable than in-person services due to its ease of access, the ability for the business to be mobile, and low overhead operating costs.

Virtual nutrition coaches can operate a successful coaching business with nothing more than a smartphone, a food tracking app, and some spreadsheets for keeping track of client data. These are the minimum tools required to deliver a virtual nutrition coaching service. Designing a scalable business that runs smoothly will require some added software, hardware, and peripheral equipment considerations, all of which are covered in *Chapter 3: Technology Considerations*.



FigureNutrition Coaching

Nutrition Program Development and Delivery

Nutrition program delivery is much like delivering virtual training sessions. The fitness professional will need to utilize a scheduling system just as they would with virtual fitness coaching. (e.g., Calendly, Vocus.io, ScheduleOnce, Zoom, etc.). They will also need to choose how to communicate with and manage clients. For example, they may use a simple system like a text message or e-mail or video calling services like Skype or WhatsApp. They may also choose to use an integrated client management software that not only allows tracking desired client metrics but also enables communication and messaging between the coach and client.

There are a variety of tools the fitness professional or nutrition coach can utilize to develop nutrition plans for clients. The options for nutrition program development range from tools like spreadsheets and Word documents, to easy-to-use apps (e.g., MyFitnessPal, Eat This Much, etc.), all the way through to full client management software systems and integrative technology. Examples of integrated technologies include the NASM Edge App, Trainerize, TrueCoach, My PT Hub, Apotheo, etc. These third-party software systems offer a host of benefits such as tracking desired client metrics (calories, hunger, energy, steps, food logs, etc.), integrated messaging and e-mail systems, scheduling integration, nutrition app integration, billing and payment systems, and so on. There is an array of client management systems and the fitness professional should do their research to consider which option will work best for both the client and coach. Professionals can choose to utilize one or a combination of all these tools as long as they are able to effectively produce, provide, and discuss nutrition plans with their clients.



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The professional will not only need to determine the best platform to develop and deliver their nutrition programs, but also the most suitable platform for them to engage with their clients on the other components of nutrition coaching. Whether via cell phone or video, the professional should schedule appointments with their clients to evaluate nutrition goals, discuss progress and setbacks, discuss daily eating habits, and encourage self-monitoring. The professional should also consider how frequently they will be providing check-ins for accountability and progress review, what communication boundaries may look like, and how frequently video catch-up calls are provided. These factors will be individual to each coach and what services are being provided.

Progress Communication

Weekly or bi-weekly check-ins should be scheduled to touch-base with each client. These can be done through the integrated client management programs that have built-in check-in systems or, alternatively, done manually with e-mails or direct messaging. There is merit in performing video calls to discuss and perform check-ins with clients. With over 55% of communication being non-verbal (body language) and 38% of communication being determined by the tone of voice (Park & Park, 2018), there may be some benefits to performing video calls versus just written reviews each week.

If the professional is performing video calls to go through weekly or bi-weekly progress reports with clients, they should exercise the same principles of preparation, communication, and environment as mentioned for fitness professionals conducting virtual training sessions. These include the following:

- Confirming scheduled appointments
- Setting up computer or video conferencing equipment (lighting, microphones, etc.)
- Being prepared for the video call: having all documentation, client metrics, and data at hand
- Being well-groomed, professional, and courteous

Coach's Corner

Nutrition Coaching Options

- One-on-one nutrition coaching via video conferencing applications (e.g., Zoom or Skype)
- One-on-one nutrition coaching via virtual tools (e.g., e-mail, cell phone, or diet and nutrition apps)
- Predesigned nutrition program sales
- Combination of two or more coaching options

Summary

The fitness professional or nutrition coach sets the stage for the client's virtual experience. The environment they construct, the way they present themselves, and the coaching they provide all dictate the experience the client will have in their virtual space. A successful virtual fitness professional understands and applies the principles of environment, presentation, and effective communication to implement great training sessions and provide excellent nutrition coaching that can rival in-person coaching.

By using the guidelines mentioned in this chapter, the fitness professional will be able to effectively adjust and configure a virtual training environment, schedule and organize training and coaching sessions, determine appropriate training equipment, and instruct a variety of clients virtually.

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